

CER-01 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

Certification handbook — master

The whole candidate journey in one document, with the detail
held in the seven that follow

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

This handbook is the candidate-facing contract for PCI certification. It states, in one place, what the three credentials are, who may apply, how the routes differ, how booking and fees work, what happens on examination day under proctoring, how results are decided, how to appeal, and what it takes to keep a credential current. Where an operational figure is not yet fixed, this handbook says so rather than guessing, and every stage points to the sibling document that holds the full rule.

— About this document

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Certification handbook — master

In one paragraph. This handbook is the candidate-facing contract for PCI certification. It states, in one place, what the three credentials are, who may apply, how the routes differ, how booking and fees work, what happens on examination day under proctoring, how results are decided, how to appeal, and what it takes to keep a credential current. Where an operational figure is not yet fixed, this handbook says so rather than guessing, and every stage points to the sibling document that holds the full rule.

Who this is for. Anyone considering a PCI credential — cost engineers, planners and schedulers, project controls engineers and managers, commercial managers, quantity surveyors, PMO analysts, project finance professionals, and project, programme and portfolio managers — together with the employers and sponsors who pay for them and need to know exactly what they are buying.

1. How to read this handbook

1.1 What this document is

This is the **master handbook**. It gives the operative rule at every stage of the candidate journey and is written so that a candidate who reads nothing else is not misled about anything material. It is deliberately not the whole rulebook: each stage has a sibling document in this series that carries the reasoning, the edge cases and the procedure. Where this handbook gives you a rule in two sentences, the sibling gives you the twenty that a hard case needs.

1.2 The map

Stage	Sibling document	What it adds
Which credential	CER-02 – The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI	What distinguishes the three, and which one is examinable today
Am I eligible	CER-03 – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments	Counting experience honestly; verification; adjustments
Which route	CER-04 – Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary	What each route grants, and what it does not
Money and dates	CER-05 – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation	The window, the cut-offs, retakes, refunds
The sitting	CER-06 – Online proctoring and the secure exam client	What is monitored, what the software can and cannot do
The outcome	CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints	Scoring, held results, the right of appeal
Staying certified	CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement	The three-year cycle and what counts

1.3 Precedence

This handbook summarises published PCI policy. **Where this handbook and a published policy differ, the published policy prevails.** Policies are updated as the scheme matures; before you rely on a specific provision — a fee, a window, a deadline, a procedural step — check the current published policy. Nothing in this handbook creates a right to a credential.

1.4 How to read a bracketed placeholder

Where you see a bracketed **CONFIRM** marker, an operational figure is genuinely not yet fixed, and the Institute has chosen to show you the gap rather than fill it with a plausible number. Those figures are confirmed at checkout or in the published policy before they can affect you. This is the same discipline the Institute applies to its own status: see §3.

— 2. The credentials

2.1 The suite

PCI certifies a suite of three co-launching credentials, all at **Leader** level, all valid for **three years**:

Code	Full name	Category
PCL-AI	PCI AI Project Controls Leader	Project controls
PFL-AI	PCI AI Project Finance Leader	Project finance
PML-AI	PCI Project Management Leader – AI	Project management

A fourth, separate offering — the **AI in Project Controls — Specialist Certificate (AIPC)** — is a certificate, not one of the three credentials. It is open entry with no prerequisite.

2.2 The one thing to know before you choose

Only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint. PFL-AI and PML-AI have competency sets but no published blueprint — no domain weightings and no item counts. If you need to know precisely what will be assessed before you commit, PCL-AI is the credential where that information exists today. [CER-02](#) sets out the difference in full, and [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) is the blueprint itself.

2.3 What a credential is not

Two distinctions that candidates get wrong, and that this handbook would rather you got right now than after paying:

1. **Certification is not membership.** PCI membership grades — Student Member (SPCI), Associate Member (APCI), Professional Member (MPCI) and Fellow (FPCI) — are a separate ladder. A credential is earned by examination; a grade is a membership standing. Buying membership does not certify you, and holding a credential is not the same as holding a grade.

2. **The honorary route is not an examined credential.** The honorary route confers the designation Honorary Fellow (PCI) by board conferral and **requires no examination**. It does not award PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI. See §5.3 and [CER-04](#).
-

— 3. Where PCI stands

PCI is a **founding-stage** certification body and says so plainly. Its certification framework is developed with reference to **ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles**. PCI is **not accredited** by ANAB, IAS or any other ISO/IEC 17024 accreditation body, and claims no governmental recognition, no university equivalence and no employment or salary outcome.

Three consequences you should read as commitments rather than caveats:

1. Operations described here in the future tense — the job-task analysis, the standard-setting study, the published recertification rules — are confirmed before they bind a candidate.
2. The Institute publishes what is not yet settled. This handbook contains bracketed placeholders for exactly that reason.
3. What the credential attests is assessed competence at the point of assessment, and thereafter under maintenance. Nothing more, and nothing less.

The Institute's published accreditation roadmap runs: standard defined — **we are here** — then student enrolment, then accreditation, then recognition.

— 4. Eligibility

4.1 The requirement

Three years of professional experience, in any field, counted on a full-time-equivalent basis. There is no degree requirement and the experience need not be in project controls.

4.2 Counting it honestly

Part-time work counts pro rata. Concurrent roles count once. Self-employment and contracting count. Career breaks do not reset the clock. [CER-03](#) works through each of these, including the cases that genuinely are ambiguous.

4.3 Verification

You declare your experience in the application, and PCI may verify what you declare **on a sample or risk basis**. A misstatement is treated as an integrity matter, not a paperwork error.

4.4 Reasonable adjustments

PCI provides reasonable adjustments so that candidates with disabilities or specific needs demonstrate their capability on equal terms. **Request an adjustment before you book, not on the day**. The standard never changes: adjustments remove barriers that have nothing to do with

the competence being assessed. The request routes, the evidence that may be asked for and the confidentiality rules are in [CER-03](#) §6.

— 5. Routes

5.1 Standard

Apply, pay the examination fee, sit the examination, and earn the credential by passing it. This is the route the rest of this handbook describes.

5.2 Founding

An invitation-only founding cohort, entered with a valid founding code, which grants membership, study access and examination access together as a fee waiver layered over the standard flow. **The credential is still earned by passing the examination.** The founding route changes what you pay, not what you must demonstrate.

5.3 Honorary

Honorary Fellow (PCI) is a board-conferred recognition of distinguished contribution. Anyone may apply; the board reviews and decides. It carries its own award reference, is recorded separately from examined credentials, and **requires no examination**. It is not PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI, and no certification follows from it.

[CER-04](#) explains all three routes, what each one costs you in evidence rather than money, and the non-public administrative routes the platform also supports.

— 6. Applying

6.1 What the application consists of

Application is fully online. Before a booking will open, all of the following must be in place:

1. an account and a **complete profile**, including the country you will sit in;
 2. your **declared experience**, meeting §4.1;
 3. a valid **government-issued photo identification** document on file, whose name matches your booking **character for character**;
 4. acceptance of the **seven required policy consents** — the candidate handbook, the examination rules, the proctoring consent, the privacy notice, the refund policy, the misconduct policy and the credential terms — each at its current version;
 5. a **valid examination entitlement**: the fee paid, not refunded or reversed, and not past its scheduling deadline;
 6. an account in good standing, with no administrative hold.
-

If a booking will not open, it is because one of those six is outstanding, or because booking is closed platform-wide. [CER-03](#) §5.1 lists the conditions in the order the platform checks them, so you can self-diagnose in a minute rather than raising a ticket.

6.2 What payment buys

The examination fee buys **examination registration access**, and opens a **12-month window** in which to schedule and sit. It does not buy a credential. Certification is a decision taken after eligibility, assessment, verification and policy requirements are all met, and no purchase confers it.

6.3 Fees

The examination fee is [\[CONFIRM: exam fee — platform seeds USD 500, legacy pack states USD 350\]](#), in US dollars, as a single payment. Fees are **route-dependent and discountable**: what you pay depends on the route you enter by and on any discount in force, and the amount that binds you is the amount shown at checkout. [CER-05](#) owns fees, refunds and retakes.

— 7. Preparing

7.1 What you are assessed against

The Body of Knowledge — **13 domains and 61 knowledge areas**, in three groups weighted **40 / 40 / 20**: project accounting and finance (Domains 1–4) at 40 %, project management principles (Domains 5–12) at 40 %, and AI knowledge and practical approach (Domain 13) at 20 %. The framework you study is the framework you are assessed against.

7.2 Training is independent of assessment

PCI owns the standard and the examination. **Certuvo** is the separate official preparation and training partner. Preparation with any provider, or none, is your choice; the certification decision is independent of training, and no course guarantees a pass. That separation is part of what makes the credential worth holding.

7.3 Using AI while you prepare

In preparation, AI is welcome — explaining a concept, generating practice scenarios, testing your reasoning. You remain responsible for verifying anything an AI tool tells you against the Body of Knowledge. **In the examination itself, AI is prohibited**, on any device, for any purpose. The examination measures your judgement, including your judgement about AI. The governing principle of the whole framework is: AI proposes; the professional disposes.

— 8. The examination

8.1 Confirmed format

Fact	Value
Duration	90 minutes
Item format	Four-option multiple choice, single best answer
Cognitive levels	Recall, application and analysis — application-weighted
Scoring	Criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve
Formula sheet	None provided in the examination
Interface languages	English, Arabic, Spanish, French, Korean, Chinese, Russian
Result	Immediate, with a domain breakdown
Validity of a pass	3 years

8.2 What is deliberately not fixed

- **The number of items.** No item count exists. It **will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis**. Any figure you see quoted elsewhere is not ours.
- **The definitive pass mark.** 65 % is the mark configured in the platform today. The definitive standard **will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study**. Both statements are true at once, and the Institute publishes both rather than the more comfortable one.

EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark explains what a standard-setting study does and why a criterion-referenced examination cannot simply pick a number.

8.3 On the day

Launch opens **15 minutes before** your slot, with a **30-minute grace period**. You will complete a system readiness check and an identity check, then a room scan. The sitting is proctored: a second monitor is blocked, prohibited applications are detected, and integrity events are recorded. You cannot quit the examination — you submit when ready, or it submits automatically when time expires. Answers are saved continuously against a **server-owned clock**, so a disconnection or a restart does not lose your work or reset your time.

CER-06 sets out exactly what is monitored, what the secure client can and cannot do — including the things it honestly cannot block — and how long evidence is kept.

— 9. Results

9.1 Immediate, with a breakdown

On submission you receive your score, a pass or fail outcome against the configured standard, and a **domain-by-domain breakdown** showing where you performed above, at or below target. For an unsuccessful candidate that breakdown is the map for targeted preparation.

9.2 When a result is held

Immediate publication is the default. Proctoring and identity evidence is **audit-only** and does not by itself delay a valid result. A result is held only where there is a genuine question about the validity of the attempt. **While a result is held you see no score, no pass or fail, and no domain breakdown** — the Institute will not show you a number it may have to withdraw. You are told plainly that the result is pending and why.

9.3 The certification decision

Passing is the central requirement, not the whole of it. The credential is awarded after eligibility, assessment, verification and policy requirements are all met. On award you receive a verifiable digital credential with a unique credential identifier and a downloadable certificate, and the credential's status can be checked by anyone through PCI's public verification.

9.4 If you disagree

You may **appeal** a decision that affects you — eligibility, examination, misconduct or certification. An appeal is reviewed independently of the people who made the original decision, and raising one never prejudices your standing. A **complaint**, about PCI's conduct, service or process, is a separate route with separate people. [CER-07](#) explains both, and [ETH-06 – Raising concerns: complaints, investigations, sanctions](#) owns the investigation and outcome side.

— 10. Keeping the credential

A credential is valid for **three years** and is maintained on a three-year cycle of continuing professional development with a **mandatory AI-currency component** — the platform records it under a CPD category named exactly that. Only approved CPD entries dated within the current cycle count.

The binding hours requirement is [\[CONFIRM: binding CPD hours per three-year cycle — 30 hours is a student-portal target, not a published requirement\]](#) and **will be published with the recertification rules**. The 30-hour figure shown in the student portal is a target the portal displays, not a rule you can be held to. [CER-08](#) sets out the cycle, the four CPD categories, what evidence is expected and what happens if a cycle lapses.

— 11. Your obligations

Certification is a standing relationship, not a transaction. As a candidate and as a credential holder you are expected to:

1. present genuine identification and sit the examination yourself;
2. use no unauthorised materials, devices or assistance of any kind, including any AI tool;
3. follow the proctor's instructions throughout the session;
4. **not disclose examination content**, during or after the sitting — reconstructing, sharing or soliciting items is misconduct however informal the setting;

5. describe your credential accurately: it belongs to you, describes competence at the point of assessment and thereafter under maintenance, and may not be transferred, altered or used in a misleading way;
6. take full professional accountability for AI-assisted work, under the Code of Ethics and the professional conduct policy. "The model said so" is never a defence.

— 12. Where candidates come unstuck

The failures below are the ones that cost candidates a sitting, and every one of them is avoidable in the week before.

- **A name mismatch.** The name on the booking must match the identification exactly, character for character. Middle names, transliterations and married names are the usual culprits. Check it the week before, not the morning of.
- **Testing on the wrong machine.** Candidates run the readiness check on a personal laptop and then sit on a work machine with a managed security policy. Run the check on the actual machine, network and room you will use.
- **A second screen still plugged in.** A second monitor connected mid-examination is detected. Unplug it, do not merely switch it off.
- **Requesting an adjustment too late.** Approved arrangements are configured in advance. A request made on the day cannot be set up in time, and a legitimate rest break that was never recorded can be logged as an irregularity.
- **Letting the window lapse.** The scheduling window runs 12 months from payment. It is not extended because the twelfth month was busy.
- **Assuming a route changes the standard.** Founding and sponsored routes change what you pay. Nobody is certified without passing.
- **Reading a fee figure from an old document.** Fees are route-dependent and discountable, and this handbook flags an unresolved conflict between two published figures. The checkout amount governs.

— 13. The candidate's checklist

Take this into the four weeks before your sitting.

Eligibility and application

- [] Three years' full-time-equivalent experience, counted per [CER-03](#)
- [] Profile complete, including country
- [] Photo identification uploaded, name matching the booking character for character
- [] All seven policy consents accepted at their current version
- [] Examination fee paid, entitlement valid, scheduling deadline noted in your own calendar

Adjustments

- [] Any reasonable adjustment requested and approved **before** booking

Booking

- ☐ Slot booked inside the 12-month window
- ☐ Free-reschedule cut-off (72 hours) and lock (24 hours) understood
- ☐ Reschedules used: ____ of a maximum of 3

Readiness

- ☐ System readiness check completed on the actual machine, network and room
- ☐ Second monitor physically disconnected
- ☐ Room clear of notes, devices and other people; a door that can be closed
- ☐ Identification physically present for the identity check

On the day

- ☐ Launch within the 15-minute early window; grace period is 30 minutes, not a plan
- ☐ Any disruption reported to the proctor immediately, and to PCI the same day

After

- ☐ Domain breakdown saved and read against the 13 domains
- ☐ Credential identifier recorded; verification link tested
- ☐ Recertification cycle end date entered in your calendar on the day you are certified

— Related

- [CER-02 – The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI](#) — which of the three you should be applying for, and which one is examinable today
- [CER-03 – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments](#) — whether your three years count, and how to ask for an adjustment
- [CER-04 – Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary](#) — what each route grants and what it withholds
- [CER-05 – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation](#) — every date and every amount, in one place
- [CER-06 – Online proctoring and the secure exam client](#) — what is watched, recorded and kept
- [CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints](#) — how the result is decided and how to challenge it
- [CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement](#) — keeping the credential alive
- [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) — the published syllabus behind the examination

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform examination and portal settings — the configured duration, pass mark, launch window, reschedule rules, scheduling window, proctoring switches and CPD settings, verified August 2026.

- PCI Candidate Handbook (<docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md>), 2026 — the predecessor candidate-facing document, authored under a retired credential code that this handbook does not carry forward.
- PCI Publication Framework, <CANONICAL-FACTS.md> §§1–9, August 2026.
- **ISO/IEC 17024** — the international standard for bodies operating certification of persons. PCI's framework is developed with reference to its principles. PCI is **not accredited** against it, and this handbook cites it as a design reference only, not as a claim of conformity assessed by anyone.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

CER-02 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI

Three credentials, one standard, and one honest difference
between them

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

PCI certifies three credentials at Leader level — PCL-AI in project controls, PFL-AI in project finance and PML-AI in project management — each valid for three years and each built on the same governed-AI principle. This document explains what distinguishes them, which competencies each one claims, how to choose between them, and the one difference that matters most before you pay: only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint. PFL-AI and PML-AI have none yet.

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The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI

In one paragraph. PCI certifies three credentials at Leader level — PCL-AI in project controls, PFL-AI in project finance and PML-AI in project management — each valid for three years and each built on the same governed-AI principle. This document explains what distinguishes them, which competencies each one claims, how to choose between them, and the one difference that matters most before you pay: only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint. PFL-AI and PML-AI have none yet.

Who this is for. Practitioners deciding which credential to sit; managers and employers deciding which credential to sponsor; anyone who has seen the three codes and cannot tell from the marketing which one describes their job.

— 1. Start with the difference that decides it

Before anything else about scope, level or audience: **only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint.** The blueprint is the document that tells you what will be assessed and in what proportion — the domain map and the weightings. For PCL-AI it exists and is published as [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#). For **PFL-AI and PML-AI there is no published blueprint: no domain weightings and no item counts.**

Both statements matter to a candidate in a practical way:

1. If you want to see precisely what you will be assessed on before you commit money and study time, PCL-AI is the credential where that information exists today.
2. The absence of a blueprint for the other two is not a gap in this document. It is a gap in the scheme, and the Institute publishes it as such rather than implying coverage it does not have.

What each of the three does have today is a **defined competency set**, seeded in the platform and explained in the S03 series. A competency set says what the credential claims about a holder. A blueprint says how an examination samples it. They are not the same instrument and one does not substitute for the other.

— 2. The three credentials

2.1 The register

Code	Full name	Display	Category	Post-nominal	Validity
PCL-AI	PCI AI Project Controls Leader	PCI PCL-AI	Project controls	PCL-AI	3 years
PFL-AI	PCI AI Project Finance Leader	PCI PFL-AI	Project finance	PFL-AI	3 years
PML-AI	PCI Project Management Leader – AI	PCI PML-AI	Project management	PML-AI	3 years

Together they are the **PCI AI Project Leadership Certification Suite**. All three sit at **Leader** level: the credential addresses the person who owns the integrity of the numbers and the decisions taken from them, not the person who assembles them for someone else to own.

2.2 PCL-AI — PCI AI Project Controls Leader

PCL-AI certifies the integrated controls discipline: the ability to plan, measure, forecast, control and finance a project, and to apply AI to that work responsibly. Its **fourteen competencies** are project controls governance; cost management; planning and scheduling; earned value management; forecasting and estimate at completion; performance measurement; project risk; commercial and contract controls; predictive analytics; AI-enabled project controls; digital reporting; automation; responsible AI; and human validation.

Recognise yourself here if your working week is spent holding a project to account: cost engineers and cost controllers, planners and schedulers, project controls engineers and managers, PMO professionals.

2.3 PFL-AI — PCI AI Project Finance Leader

PFL-AI certifies the finance side of the same discipline: whether a project can be financed, on what terms, and whether the model that says so can be defended. Its **nineteen competencies** are project finance; infrastructure finance; financial modelling; investment appraisal; capital structure; debt and equity; project bankability; the debt-service, loan-life and project-life coverage ratios; public-private partnerships and concessions; project contracts; financial close; commercial and financial risk; sustainable finance; Islamic project finance; AI-enabled financial modelling; predictive cash-flow analysis; digital due diligence; responsible AI; and human validation.

Recognise yourself here if you build, challenge or rely on the model that decides whether a project proceeds: project finance analysts and managers, infrastructure and capital-markets professionals, commercial and investment leads, and controls professionals whose work terminates in a funding decision.

2.4 PML-AI — PCI Project Management Leader - AI

PML-AI certifies delivery leadership with controls literacy and governed AI built in. Its **twenty-four competencies** are project management; project leadership; project initiation; business cases; governance; scope and requirements; planning and execution; stakeholder leadership; procurement; contracts and commercial delivery; cost, schedule and risk integration; predictive delivery; agile delivery; hybrid delivery; quality and change management; benefits realisation; sustainability; project closure; AI-enabled project management; decision intelligence; digital delivery; automation; responsible AI; and human accountability.

Recognise yourself here if you are accountable for the outcome rather than for a control function within it: project, programme and portfolio managers, delivery leads, and controls professionals moving into delivery accountability.

2.5 The competency counts are not a ranking

Fourteen, nineteen and twenty-four are the sizes of three differently shaped domains, not a hierarchy of difficulty. PFL-AI carries more competencies than PCL-AI because project finance decomposes into more distinct instruments, not because it is harder or worth more. Nothing in the suite makes one credential senior to another; all three are Leader level.

— 3. What all three share

3.1 The governing principle

AI proposes; the professional disposes. Across all three credentials, AI may draft, calculate, summarise, detect and forecast — and a competent human validates, explains and owns every conclusion that carries a professional's name. Every competency set ends on the same two entries for this reason: **responsible AI**, and **human validation** or **human accountability**. That is not decoration. It is the claim the credential makes about its holder.

3.2 Common delivery settings

The Institute configures delivery once and applies it across the suite, with the ability to override a setting for an individual certification where the assessment genuinely requires it. The common settings today are a **90-minute** sitting, **four-option multiple-choice items with a single best answer**, **criterion-referenced** scoring, **no formula sheet** provided, an **immediate result with a domain breakdown**, seven interface languages, and **three-year** validity.

Two figures are deliberately not settled and are stated the same way for every credential in the suite: **no item count exists**, and it will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis; and the **65 %** pass mark configured in the platform is not yet the definitive standard, which will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study. [CER-01](#) §8 and [EXB-05](#) carry the detail.

3.3 One maintenance regime

All three are maintained the same way: a three-year cycle of continuing professional development with a mandatory AI-currency component. A credential holder in project finance and a credential holder in controls face the same obligation to stay current with a technology that is changing both. See [CER-08](#).

— 4. The fourth offering, which is not one of the three

The **AI in Project Controls — Specialist Certificate (AIPC)** is a certificate, not a credential in the suite. It is **open entry with no prerequisite**, drawn from Domain 13 of the PCL-AI Body of Knowledge, and assessed by scenario items plus an applied AI task rather than by the suite's examination format.

It is the right instrument if you want a governed grounding in AI for controls work without committing to a Leader-level credential — and the wrong one if what you need is the credential. It does not carry a post-nominal in the suite, is not a step on a certification ladder that ends in PCL-AI, and does not satisfy any part of the suite's requirements.

— 5. Choosing between them

5.1 Choose on accountability, not on job title

Job titles are unreliable across sectors and countries; the same title means three different jobs in three different companies. Choose instead on the question you are most often the last person to answer:

The question you own	The credential
Is this forecast defensible, and what does the data actually support?	PCL-AI
Can this be financed, on what terms, and does the model survive challenge?	PFL-AI
Should we proceed, and can we deliver what we have committed to?	PML-AI

If two of those describe you, take the one that describes the decision your name appears against.

5.2 Choose on the evidence available today

If your decision depends on knowing exactly what will be assessed — because you are budgeting study time, building a corporate training plan, or answering to someone who will ask — PCL-AI is the credential with a published blueprint. That is a statement about publication status, not about quality.

5.3 You are not choosing for ever

Credentials in the suite are separate awards, not levels of one award. Holding one does not exempt you from another's assessment, and holding one does not preclude the others. There is no order in which they must be taken.

— 6. How this goes wrong

- **Treating the suite as a ladder.** Candidates assume PCL-AI is the entry credential and PML-AI the senior one, then plan a multi-year sequence that does not exist. Three parallel awards, one level.
- **Choosing PFL-AI or PML-AI expecting a published blueprint.** Read §1 again before you pay. The competency set is published; the examination blueprint is not.
- **Mistaking the specialist certificate for a credential.** AIPC is open entry and does not certify Leader-level competence in anything. It is a good first step and a poor substitute.
- **Confusing a credential with a membership grade.** SPCI, APCI, MPCAI and FPCI are membership standings on a separate ladder. A credential is earned by examination. CER-01 §2.3.
- **Reading the competency count as a difficulty rating.** See §2.5.
- **Assuming the AI content is a separate module you can skip.** AI is examined throughout the framework and carries 20 % in its own right in the PCL-AI blueprint. It is not an appendix.

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the whole candidate journey, of which this is the first decision
- [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) — the published blueprint referred to throughout §1
- [CMP-03 – PCL-AI: the fourteen competencies](#) — what each PCL-AI competency means and how it is evidenced
- [CMP-04 – PFL-AI: the nineteen competencies](#) — the same treatment for project finance
- [CMP-05 – PML-AI: the twenty-four competencies](#) — the same treatment for delivery leadership
- [CER-04 – Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary](#) — how you enter, once you have chosen

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform certification records and seeded competency sets, verified August 2026 — the source of the fourteen, nineteen and twenty-four competencies quoted in §2.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §§1, 3, 7 and 9, August 2026.
- Note on a known inconsistency: the platform database records all three credentials at **Leader** level while one public page currently renders "Level: Professional". Leader is correct, and the word professional elsewhere in the framework refers to a competency scale, not to this credential level.

— Status and version

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Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments

Whether your three years count, what the application actually asks for, and how to get an adjustment approved in time

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

PCI's entry requirement is three years of professional experience in any field, counted on a full-time-equivalent basis, with no degree requirement. This document shows how to count those years honestly in the awkward cases — part-time, concurrent roles, self-employment, career breaks — what the application asks for and in what order the platform checks it, how experience is verified on a sample or risk basis, and how to request a reasonable adjustment so that it is in place before you book.

— About this document

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Examples. All worked examples are illustrative and fictional. Figures are chosen to demonstrate a method, not to describe any real project, organisation or market. Sample examination items, where they appear, are study material maintained separately from any live examination bank.

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Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments

In one paragraph. PCI's entry requirement is three years of professional experience in any field, counted on a full-time-equivalent basis, with no degree requirement. This document shows how to count those years honestly in the awkward cases — part-time, concurrent roles, self-employment, career breaks — what the application asks for and in what order the platform checks it, how experience is verified on a sample or risk basis, and how to request a reasonable adjustment so that it is in place before you book.

Who this is for. Prospective candidates working out whether they qualify; career changers whose experience is not in project controls; employers and sponsors confirming that a member of staff is eligible before committing a budget; and any candidate who needs an adjustment to sit on equal terms.

— 1. The entry requirement

1.1 The rule

Three years of professional experience, in any field, counted on a full-time-equivalent basis. There is **no degree requirement**, and the experience **need not be in project controls**.

1.2 What the rule is doing

Two things, and it is worth being clear about both.

First, it sets a floor rather than a filter. Three years is long enough that a candidate has met a real deadline, a real budget and a real disagreement about a number, and short enough that it does not exclude the people the discipline actually recruits. Talent enters project controls from engineering, finance, construction, the trades and non-traditional routes, and a degree is not a reliable proxy for project-controls capability.

Second — and this is the part candidates most often miss — **meeting the eligibility criteria confirms only that you are ready to be assessed**. It is not a partial qualification, it does not contribute to your result, and no amount of experience beyond three years improves your standing. The credential is earned by passing the examination and nothing else.

1.3 What "professional experience" means

Paid work, in a role with defined responsibilities, for which you could describe what you were accountable for and name someone who could confirm it. Full-time study is not professional experience. Voluntary or unpaid work in a role with genuine responsibility is a case to raise with PCI before you apply rather than to assume in either direction. PCI interpretation: the test is responsibility and verifiability, not sector, seniority or job title.

— 2. Counting your three years

The four rules below are the published counting rules. They resolve most histories; §3 works one through arithmetically.

2.1 Part-time counts pro rata

Part-time work counts in proportion to full time. Two years at half-time contributes approximately one year. Use the contracted proportion of full-time hours in the same role, not the hours you actually worked in your busiest month.

2.2 Concurrent roles count once

Overlapping positions do not double the time. A period during which you held two roles is one period of experience. PCI interpretation: no calendar period is ever counted at more than one full-time equivalent, however many roles ran through it.

2.3 Self-employment and contracting count

Provided the work can be described and, if asked, verified. Being your own employer is not a disqualification; being unable to evidence what you did is a problem in any employment arrangement.

2.4 Career breaks do not reset the clock

Experience either side of a gap counts in full. Parental leave, illness, redundancy, study and travel break the continuity of employment, not the validity of the experience before it.

2.5 What is not covered by a rule

Some histories will still be ambiguous — a role that was nominally full-time but seasonal, an internship with real accountability, a family business without formal contracts. There is no published rule for every case, and inventing one here would be worse than saying so. Describe the position accurately in the application and raise it with PCI before booking. A case put honestly in advance is an eligibility question; the same case discovered later is an integrity question.

— 3. Worked example — counting a mixed history

Illustrative figures. The candidate and the dates are invented for the purpose of showing the arithmetic; nothing here describes a real person.

The history. A candidate has:

- 18 months as a full-time site engineer;
- 24 months as a cost analyst at 0.6 of full-time hours;
- of those same 24 months, 12 months also spent as a part-time lecturer at 0.4 of full-time hours;
- an 11-month career break;
- 9 months full-time as a self-employed contractor.

The calculation. Units are months, expressed as full-time equivalent (FTE), to one decimal place.

Period	Duration	FTE factor	FTE months	Rule applied
Site engineer	18	1.0	$18 \times 1.0 = 18.0$	Full-time
Cost analyst	24	0.6	$24 \times 0.6 = 14.4$	Pro rata (§2.1)
Lecturer (concurrent)	12	0.4	counted at 0.0	Concurrent (§2.2)
Career break	11	—	0.0	No credit, no reset (§2.4)
Self-employed contractor	9	1.0	$9 \times 1.0 = 9.0$	Self-employment (§2.3)

Total = $18.0 + 14.4 + 0.0 + 0.0 + 9.0 = 41.4$ FTE months = **3.45 years**.

The answer. 3.45 years is above the three-year requirement, so this candidate is eligible.

The assumptions the answer depends on. That the FTE factors are the contracted proportions and can be evidenced from contracts or payslips; that the lecturing months overlapped the cost-analyst role entirely, so no part of them falls outside it; and that the 11-month break contains no other paid work. Change any of those and the arithmetic changes. Note that the concurrent lecturing months are not lost because lecturing is worth less — they are not counted because the calendar period they occupy has already been counted once.

— 4. Declaring and verifying experience

4.1 What you declare

Roles, dates, and a brief description of your responsibilities. Write the description in terms of what you were accountable for rather than what the team delivered.

4.2 What to keep

Keep a simple record alongside your application, whether or not anyone asks for it:

- role title and employer or client;
- start and end dates, to the month;
- contracted proportion of full-time hours for any part-time period;
- one line on what you were actually responsible for;
- the name and current contact details of a person who could confirm it.

That record takes twenty minutes to write while you remember, and is very difficult to reconstruct two years later when a verification request arrives.

4.3 How verification works

PCI may verify what you declare **on a sample or risk basis**. Not every application is verified; verification is not a sign of suspicion; and being asked is not an adverse finding.

4.4 Misstatement

A misstatement of experience is treated as an **integrity matter, not a paperwork error**. Correcting your own declaration before it is relied upon is always the cheaper move, and PCI would rather receive a correction than discover a discrepancy.

— 5. The application

5.1 What must be in place before a booking will open

Application is fully online. The platform checks the following, and a booking will not open until every one is satisfied:

1. **Examination entitlement** — the fee paid, not refunded, failed or reversed.
2. **The entitlement is still live** — its scheduling deadline has not passed (see [CER-05](#) §2).
3. **Profile completeness** — including the country you will sit in.
4. **Identity document** — a government-issued photo identification document on file. The most recent document governs: if none has been uploaded, or the most recent was rejected, booking is blocked until you upload again. A freshly submitted document satisfies the gate; verification by staff is an audit action, not a queue you wait in.
5. **Policy consents** — all seven accepted at their current version (§5.2).
6. **Account standing** — no administrative hold, suspension or deactivation on the account.

A seventh condition sits outside your control: booking can be closed platform-wide, in which case no candidate can book.

Knowing this list is worth a support ticket. When "book" does not appear, the cause is almost always one of items 1 to 6, and you can resolve most of them yourself in ten minutes.

5.2 The seven consents

Before booking you accept, at their current version: the **candidate handbook**, the **examination rules**, the **proctoring consent**, the **privacy notice**, the **refund policy**, the **misconduct policy** and the **credential terms**. Each acceptance is recorded with its policy version and timestamp.

Two consequences follow. You cannot later say you were not told, because the version you accepted is on record. And PCI cannot quietly change a policy under you, because the same record shows which version you agreed to and a changed version has to be accepted afresh.

5.3 The name on your identification

The name on your booking must match your identification **exactly, character for character**. This is the most avoidable cause of exam-day failure. Check it the week before you sit, not the morning of.

— 6. Reasonable adjustments

6.1 The commitment

PCI provides reasonable adjustments so that candidates with disabilities or specific needs can demonstrate their capability on equal terms, **without compromising the standard**. Adjustments remove barriers that have nothing to do with the competence being assessed. They never alter what competence means: the same knowledge, the same skill, the same pass mark. The promise is a level field, never a lower bar.

6.2 Request before you book

Request an adjustment **from your account, before booking** — not on the day. This is not administrative preference; it is the only way the arrangement can actually work:

- extended time is configured in the platform in advance, and approved extra minutes genuinely extend the duration of your examination rather than being added by someone watching a clock;
- agreed rest breaks are recorded with the proctoring arrangements, so that a legitimate break is never flagged as an irregularity;
- assistive technology is checked for compatibility with the secure environment while there is still time to resolve a problem.

Requests should be submitted **[CONFIRM: the minimum notice period for a reasonable-adjustment request before booking or before the scheduled sitting]** in advance. Until that notice period is published, submit as early as you can and do not book until your request has been decided.

6.3 What you can request

The platform recognises four request categories: **extra time**, a **separate setting**, **assistive technology**, and **other** — the last existing precisely because a fixed list would fail the candidate whose need is not on it. Describe what you need and why, in your own words.

6.4 Evidence

Supporting evidence may be requested to determine the appropriate adjustment. The purpose is to match the adjustment to the barrier, not to test whether you deserve one.

6.5 How a request is handled

A request is submitted, reviewed, and decided as approved or rejected, with any approved extra minutes recorded against your account and applied automatically to your sitting. A decision carries a right of appeal like any other decision that affects you (CER-07 §6).

6.6 Confidentiality

Accommodation information is handled on a strict need-to-know basis and kept apart from assessment judgements. **The proctor knows that an arrangement exists, and what to do about it — not why it was granted.** Requesting an adjustment has no bearing on how your examination is marked, in either direction, and no marker sees it.

— 7. Accessibility beyond adjustments

Some accessibility is built in rather than requested. The examination interface is available in **seven languages** — English, Arabic, Spanish, French, Korean, Chinese and Russian — and the Arabic interface is laid out right-to-left rather than merely translated. Language choice is not an adjustment and needs no approval.

If a barrier you face is not addressed by either the built-in provision or the four request categories, raise it. A scheme that only accommodates the needs it anticipated is not accessible; it is lucky.

— 8. How this goes wrong

- **Waiting for eligibility to be "approved" before paying.** Eligibility is declared and verified on a sample or risk basis; there is no separate approval step that unlocks the rest of the process.
 - **Counting concurrent roles twice.** The most common inflation in a mixed history, and the easiest to spot in verification. §2.2.
 - **Counting a career break as disqualifying.** The opposite error, and it costs eligible people a credential they already qualify for. §2.4.
 - **Uploading identification whose name differs by one character.** §5.3.
 - **Requesting an adjustment after booking.** By then the configuration window has usually closed, and the choice becomes sitting without the adjustment or rescheduling. §6.2.
 - **Assuming a rejected identity document has been chased.** The most recent document governs. If yours was rejected, nothing proceeds until you upload another.
 - **Describing responsibilities as team achievements.** "The project delivered under budget" tells a verifier nothing about you. "I owned the cost report and the monthly variance analysis for a four-package scope" is verifiable.
-

— Related

- [CER-01 — Certification handbook — master](#) — the whole journey, of which eligibility is the first gate
- [CER-04 — Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary](#) — how eligibility differs by route
- [CER-05 — Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation](#) — what happens once the gates in §5.1 are clear
- [CAR-07 — Building a portfolio of evidence](#) — how to keep the experience record §4.2 asks for

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform application and booking gate, consent records and accommodation request records, verified August 2026 — the source of the six booking conditions in §5.1, the seven consents in §5.2 and the four request categories in §6.3.
 - PCI Candidate Handbook ([docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md](#)), 2026.
-

- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §4.4, August 2026.

— Status and version

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CER-04 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary

What each route changes, what it never changes, and the one route that involves no examination at all

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

There are three public routes into PCI. The standard route is application, payment and examination. The founding route is an invitation-only cohort entered with a code that waives the fee and bundles membership, study and examination access — the examination itself is unchanged. The honorary route confers the designation Honorary Fellow (PCI) by board decision and requires no examination, awards no certification, and grants no post-nominal in the credential suite. This document states what each route changes and what no route changes.

— About this document

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Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary

In one paragraph. There are three public routes into PCI. The standard route is application, payment and examination. The founding route is an invitation-only cohort entered with a code that waives the fee and bundles membership, study and examination access — the examination itself is unchanged. The honorary route confers the designation Honorary Fellow (PCI) by board decision and requires no examination, awards no certification, and grants no post-nominal in the credential suite. This document states what each route changes and what no route changes.

Who this is for. Prospective candidates deciding how to enter; employers and sponsors funding a cohort; anyone who has been offered a founding code and wants to know what it is worth; and anyone considering an honorary nomination, for themselves or for someone else.

— 1. The one rule that survives every route

No route awards a credential without an examination. The standard route and the founding route both end in the same sitting, marked to the same standard. The honorary route does not end in a credential at all.

That sentence is the whole document in one line, and it is written first because the alternative is a reader who works it out in month three. A route changes **what you pay** and **how you were invited**. It never changes what you have to demonstrate.

— 2. The three public routes at a glance

	Standard	Founding	Honorary
Who may enter	Anyone meeting the eligibility rule	Invited holders of a valid founding code	Anyone may apply; the board decides
Examination required	Yes	Yes	No
What is awarded on success	PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI	The same credential, on the same terms	The designation Honorary Fellow (PCI)
Eligibility rule	Three years, any field	Three years, any field, self-declared with evidence	Distinguished contribution, judged by the board
What you pay	The examination fee	Waived by the code, within its window	No examination fee, because there is no examination
Who decides	Assessment, then the certification decision	Assessment, then the certification decision	The board
Post-nominal in the credential suite	Yes	Yes	No

— 3. The standard route

3.1 What it is

Apply online, meet the eligibility rule of three years' professional experience in any field, satisfy the booking conditions, pay the examination fee, book inside your window, sit under proctoring, and earn the credential by passing.

3.2 What it costs

A single examination fee in US dollars, which opens a scheduling window rather than buying a credential. Fees are route-dependent and discountable, and the amount that binds you is the amount shown at checkout. The figure itself — including an unresolved conflict between two published amounts — is owned by [CER-05](#) §4, together with the window, refunds and retakes.

3.3 Why it is the reference route

Every other route is described by how it differs from this one. If you are reading a claim about PCI certification and cannot tell which route it describes, assume the standard route and check.

— 4. The founding route

4.1 What it is

An **invitation-only founding cohort**, entered with a valid founding code. One code grants **membership, study access and examination access together**: a full fee waiver layered over the standard flow, valid inside the window set on the code.

4.2 What it changes

Money and access, and nothing else. A founding candidate:

- declares the same eligibility — three years of professional experience in any field — and supports the declaration with evidence at the point of application;
- sits the same examination, of the same duration, marked to the same standard;
- receives the same credential, with the same validity, subject to the same recertification obligation.

Founding applications are reviewed. An application is recorded as approved or pending review, and may be rejected or, later, revoked. Approval of a founding application is approval of entry to the cohort — not of the credential.

4.3 What it does not change

A founding candidate is not certified by being founding. The credential is still earned by passing the examination. Nothing about founding status confers a result, softens a mark, or shortens a requirement.

4.4 Availability

The founding cohort exists inside a defined window. **[CONFIRM: whether the founding-route window is currently open and the date on which it closes]** — check the current published position before planning around it, and do not assume a code you were sent last quarter is still live.

4.5 Why the Institute runs a founding route at all

PCI interpretation. A founding-stage certification body needs candidates before it has a track record, and candidates need a reason to go first. The founding route pays for that asymmetry with a fee waiver rather than with a lowered standard, because a lowered standard would devalue the credential of exactly the people who took the risk. Founding candidates are the cohort with the strongest interest in the examination being hard.

— 5. The honorary route

5.1 State it plainly

The honorary route requires no examination. It confers the designation **Honorary Fellow (PCI)** — a board-conferred recognition of distinguished contribution to the discipline. It does **not** award PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI. An honorary award is recorded separately from examined credentials, under its own award reference series, precisely so that the two can never be confused by a reader, an employer or a verification check.

5.2 How it works

Anyone may apply; the board reviews and decides. An application asks for your professional history, qualifications, certifications and a summary of the contribution being put forward, with supporting documents. The decision is the board's, and the citation — the board's stated reason — is recorded with the award and shown on verification.

An honorary award is **revocable**. It can be withdrawn for cause, and the record shows when and why.

5.3 What it is not

- It is **not a certification**. No examination has been passed, so no assessed competence is attested.
- It is **not a post-nominal in the credential suite**. An honorary recipient does not write PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI after their name.
- It is **not a membership grade**. Membership grades — Student Member (SPCI), Associate Member (APCI), Professional Member (MPCI) and Fellow (FPCI) — are a separate ladder governed by membership rules. Whether an honorary award interacts with a membership grade is a membership question, not a certification one, and this handbook does not decide it.

5.4 Describing an honorary award honestly

If you hold one, describe it as what it is: an honorary recognition conferred by the Institute's board. Do not describe it as certification, do not list it among certifications on a professional profile, and do not let a reader infer an examination that did not happen. The Institute records honorary awards separately for the same reason.

— 6. The administrative routes

The platform also supports routes that are not marketed as public entry points but exist because real programmes need them: a **sponsored** route where a third party funds the candidate, a **complimentary** route, **full** and **partial fee waivers**, and a non-public **test** route used for platform verification.

Every one of them is a **billing arrangement**. They determine who pays and how much. None alters eligibility, the examination, the pass standard, the certification decision or the recertification obligation. A candidate entered under a sponsorship sits exactly the examination a self-funding candidate sits.

Two consequences worth stating for employers:

1. **Sponsorship buys an attempt, not an outcome.** A sponsoring organisation is buying its people the opportunity to be assessed. If it needs a guaranteed number of passes, it is buying the wrong thing from the wrong kind of body.
2. **The certification decision is not the sponsor's.** The credential belongs to the individual, and the assessment result is theirs. A sponsor is not a party to the certification decision.

— 7. How this goes wrong

- **Assuming honorary is a fast route to the credential.** It is not a route to the credential at all. §5.1.
- **Listing an honorary designation among certifications.** It reads as a certification the holder does not have, and it is the kind of error a hostile reader finds first. §5.4.
- **Treating a founding code as a certificate.** A code grants access. Nothing else. §4.3.
- **Letting a founding code's window lapse.** The waiver lives inside a window; the window closes whether or not you booked. §4.4.
- **Sponsors expecting influence over the result.** §6.
- **Comparing route fees without checking route conditions.** A waiver bundled with membership and study access is not the same product as a discount on an examination fee, and the two do not compare on price alone.

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the full journey once you have chosen a route

- [CER-02](#) – The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI — which credential you are entering for
- [CER-03](#) – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments — the eligibility rule that every route shares
- [CER-05](#) – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation — what each route actually costs, and when

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform route records, founding-application records and honorary-award records, verified August 2026 — including the deliberate separation of honorary awards from issued credentials in the data model.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §5, August 2026.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation

Every date and every amount that governs a sitting, including the ones not yet settled

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

Payment opens a twelve-month window in which to schedule and sit; a slot may be chosen up to 365 days ahead; launch opens 15 minutes before the slot with a 30-minute grace period; a booking may be rescheduled free of charge up to 72 hours before, a maximum of three times, and locks 24 hours before the start. This document sets those dates out as one timeline, states the examination fee conflict rather than choosing a side, and is explicit about the refund, retake and mid-window reschedule terms that are not yet published.

— About this document

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Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation

In one paragraph. Payment opens a twelve-month window in which to schedule and sit; a slot may be chosen up to 365 days ahead; launch opens 15 minutes before the slot with a 30-minute grace period; a booking may be rescheduled free of charge up to 72 hours before, a maximum of three times, and locks 24 hours before the start. This document sets those dates out as one timeline, states the examination fee conflict rather than choosing a side, and is explicit about the refund, retake and mid-window reschedule terms that are not yet published.

Who this is for. Candidates planning a sitting around a working life; employers and sponsors scheduling a cohort; and anyone who needs to know the exact moment a change stops being possible.

— 1. The dates, in one table

Event	Rule
Scheduling deadline	12 months from payment. The entitlement expires on that date.
Booking horizon	A slot may be scheduled within a 365-day window
Launch opens	15 minutes before the scheduled start
Grace period	30 minutes after the scheduled start
Free reschedule	Up to 72 hours before the scheduled start
Maximum reschedules	3
Booking locks	24 hours before the scheduled start

All times are in the timezone recorded on the booking. Record that timezone yourself when you book; a candidate who travels between booking and sitting is the classic case of a slot missed by exactly the number of hours nobody checked.

— 2. The two clocks

There are two, and confusing them is the most expensive mistake in this document.

The entitlement clock starts when you pay and runs for **12 months**. It governs whether you may hold a booking at all. When it expires, the entitlement is spent whether or not you sat, and a fresh examination fee is required.

The booking clock governs a single sitting: when launch opens, when the grace period ends, when the free-reschedule cut-off passes and when the booking locks. It restarts every time you reschedule.

Rescheduling resets the booking clock. It does **not** extend the entitlement clock. Three reschedules, each pushing a sitting a month later, will move you past a scheduling deadline that has not moved at all.

— 3. Before a booking will open

A booking will not open until your entitlement is valid, your profile is complete, a government-issued photo identification document is on file, all seven policy consents are accepted at their current version, and your account is in good standing. Those six conditions, the order in which they are checked and how to clear each one are owned by [CER-03](#) §5.1.

Booking can also be closed platform-wide, in which case nothing you do to your own account will open it.

— 4. Fees

4.1 The examination fee

[CONFIRM: exam fee — platform seeds USD 500, legacy pack states USD 350]

Two published figures disagree, and this handbook prints both rather than choosing between them. Neither is quoted here as the price. **The amount shown at checkout is the amount that binds you**, and it is the only figure that governs a transaction.

4.2 What the fee is and is not

All fees are stated in **US dollars** and paid as a **single one-time payment**. The examination fee buys examination registration access and opens the 12-month scheduling window. It does not buy a credential: certification is a decision taken after eligibility, assessment, verification and policy requirements are met, and no purchase confers it.

4.3 Fees are route-dependent and discountable

What you pay depends on the route you enter by and on any discount in force at the time. The founding route waives the examination fee inside its window; sponsored, complimentary and partial-waiver arrangements change who pays and how much ([CER-04](#) §§4 and 6). Discount codes exist, are administrator-managed, and may be limited by product, by number of uses or to one use per person. None of this changes the examination.

4.4 Membership and renewal

Membership is a **separate purchase on a separate ladder**, seeded in the platform at **USD 99**, with renewal seeded at **USD 99**. Buying membership does not certify you and is not the examination fee. [CER-01](#) §2.3 explains the distinction; [CER-08](#) covers what renewal maintains.

4.5 The retake fee

No retake figure is quoted here. The platform currently carries the retake product as inactive, and the published policy is that the retake fee is confirmed and displayed **before any retake booking is completed**. If you are offered a retake price by any other source, it is not ours.

— 5. Booking a sitting

Choose a date and time inside your window. Launch opens **15 minutes before** your scheduled start and stays open for a **30-minute grace period**.

Treat the grace period as an insurance policy, not a plan. It exists so that a five-minute problem with a camera driver does not cost you a sitting; it does not exist so that you can start half an hour late with half an hour less composure. Candidates who launch in the early window and fail the readiness check still have time to fix it. Candidates who launch at minute 29 do not.

If you do not launch within the grace period, the booking is **marked missed**. A documented incident — a genuine technical failure, for instance — is considered under the examination administration policy; open a support case with evidence, promptly, while the evidence still exists.

— 6. Rescheduling

6.1 The rule

You may reschedule **free of charge up to 72 hours before** your scheduled start, **up to three times**. Bookings **lock 24 hours before** the start, after which the booking cannot be changed.

6.2 The gap between the two cut-offs

Between 72 hours and 24 hours before a sitting, the free-reschedule right has passed but the booking has not yet locked. [CONFIRM: whether a reschedule requested inside 72 hours but before the 24-hour lock is permitted, and on what terms]. Until that is published, plan on the 72-hour figure as your real deadline.

6.3 Reschedules are counted, not renewed

Three is the maximum across the entitlement, not three per booking. The count travels with you. Before you move a sitting for convenience, ask whether you would rather still have that move available in eleven months' time when the reason is not convenience.

— 7. Cancellation and refunds

[CONFIRM: the published refund and cancellation terms — a refund policy consent is required of every candidate before booking, but its terms are not stated in the platform settings].

Two things are confirmed and worth stating in the meantime. Accepting the refund policy is one of the seven consents required before you may book, so you will have read the operative terms at their current version before any money is at risk. And the scheduling window **cannot be extended**: if the 12-month entitlement lapses without a sitting, a new examination fee is required. Lapse is not a cancellation and does not create a refund.

— 8. Retakes

Not passing first time is not unusual, and the retake rules are built to be fair rather than punitive.

- **You may resit.** Eligibility is unchanged between attempts — you do not requalify to try again, subject only to conduct requirements.
- **An authorisation carries one attempt by default.** A further sitting requires a further authorisation.
- **A waiting period applies between attempts.** [\[CONFIRM: the retake waiting period — the platform default is zero days while the published candidate policy describes a short waiting period\]](#).
- **The fee is confirmed before booking.** \$4.5.
- **Confirmed misconduct may remove the right to resit.** See [CER-07](#) and [ETH-06](#).

A resit is a complete, fresh examination drawn to the same blueprint and the same passing standard, so memorising a previous sitting is neither possible nor useful. A pass after previous attempts confers exactly the same credential as a first-time pass — there is no annotation, and no one can tell from the credential how many attempts it took.

— 9. Worked example — one entitlement, one timeline

Illustrative figures. The dates are invented to show how the two clocks interact; they describe no real candidate.

The facts. A candidate pays on **3 September 2026** and books a sitting for **14 May 2027 at 09:00** in the timezone recorded on the booking.

Milestone	Date and time	How it is derived
Payment	3 Sep 2026	—
Scheduling deadline	3 Sep 2027	Payment + 12 months
Free-reschedule cut-off	11 May 2027, 09:00	Scheduled start – 72 hours
Booking locks	13 May 2027, 09:00	Scheduled start – 24 hours
Launch opens	14 May 2027, 08:45	Scheduled start – 15 minutes
Grace period ends	14 May 2027, 09:30	Scheduled start + 30 minutes

The trap. On 10 May the candidate reschedules — legitimately, free, and within the rules — to **20 September 2027**. The booking clock restarts and every cut-off above recalculates. The scheduling

deadline does not move: it is still **3 September 2027**, seventeen days before the new sitting. The entitlement expires before the examination happens, and a new examination fee is required.

The assumption the answer depends on. That the 12-month deadline runs from the payment date and is not extended by rescheduling — which is the published rule. Check the deadline on your own account before every reschedule, not after.

— 10. How this goes wrong

- **Rescheduling past the entitlement deadline.** \$9. The single most expensive error available to a candidate, and it is invisible at the moment it is made.
- **Booking in one timezone and living in another.** The booking's recorded timezone governs.
- **Treating the grace period as a start window.** \$5.
- **Spending reschedules on convenience.** Three, in total, for the whole entitlement. \$6.3.
- **Planning around the 24-hour lock.** The lock is when change becomes impossible, not when it becomes free. The free deadline is 72 hours. \$6.
- **Quoting a fee from an older document.** Two published figures disagree; checkout governs. \$4.1.
- **Assuming a lapsed window will be extended on request.** It will not. \$7.

— 11. The dates worksheet

Fill this in the day you pay, in your own calendar, with reminders — not in this document.

Field	Your value
Payment date	
Scheduling deadline (payment + 12 months)	
Booked date, time and timezone	
Free-reschedule cut-off (start – 72 h)	
Booking lock (start – 24 h)	
Launch opens (start – 15 min)	
Reschedules used, of 3	
Reminder set for 60 days before the scheduling deadline	

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the journey these dates sit inside
- [CER-03 – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments](#) — the six conditions that must clear before a booking opens, and why adjustments must be requested first

- [CER-06 – Online proctoring and the secure exam client](#) — what happens after launch
- [CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints](#) — the outcome, and what to do if you dispute it

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform booking, entitlement and pricing settings — reschedule cut-off, maximum reschedules, launch window, grace period, scheduling deadline and seeded prices, verified August 2026.
- PCI Candidate Handbook ([docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md](#)), 2026.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §§4.1 and 4.3, August 2026 — including the recorded conflict between the platform's seeded examination fee and the legacy candidate pack.

— Status and version

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Online proctoring and the secure exam client

What is checked, what is watched, what is kept — and what the software honestly cannot do

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A PCI sitting is proctored: you complete a readiness check, an identity check against government-issued photo identification and a room scan, then sit in a locked-down environment that blocks a second monitor, detects prohibited applications and records integrity events against a server-owned clock. This document explains each step, states plainly what the downloadable secure client can and cannot enforce — it cannot block Ctrl+Alt+Del, and says so — describes what evidence is captured and kept, and explains why a result held for integrity review shows you no score at all until it is resolved.

— About this document

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Online proctoring and the secure exam client

In one paragraph. A PCI sitting is proctored: you complete a readiness check, an identity check against government-issued photo identification and a room scan, then sit in a locked-down environment that blocks a second monitor, detects prohibited applications and records integrity events against a server-owned clock. This document explains each step, states plainly what the downloadable secure client can and cannot enforce — it cannot block Ctrl+Alt+Del, and says so — describes what evidence is captured and kept, and explains why a result held for integrity review shows you no score at all until it is resolved.

Who this is for. Candidates preparing to sit; IT and information-security staff being asked to approve the client on a corporate machine; and employers who want to know what their sponsored candidates are consenting to.

— 1. What proctoring is for

Proctoring protects one thing: that a pass means the same for everyone who earns it. A credential that can be obtained by a candidate with a second screen, an open browser or a colleague in the room is not worth holding, and the people it damages most are the ones who passed honestly.

That is the whole justification, and it sets the limit of what the Institute may reasonably do. Proctoring is entitled to establish that the right person sat the examination unaided. It is not entitled to anything else about your life, your household or your machine.

— 2. Consent comes first

The **proctoring consent** is one of the seven policy consents you accept before you may book (CER-03 §5.2). Each acceptance is recorded with the policy version and the date. There is no sitting without it, and there is no proctoring before it.

— 3. Before you launch

3.1 The readiness check

A short **system readiness check** confirms that your camera, microphone, network connection, full-screen behaviour and environment are workable, and records the browser and screen configuration it found. **The readiness check itself records nothing about you** — it establishes that the equipment works. Camera and microphone access are requested to confirm they function and to support the proctored session that follows.

Run it on the **actual machine, network and room** you will use, well before exam day. A check passed on a personal laptop tells you nothing about a work machine with a managed security policy, a VPN and an endpoint agent.

3.2 The identity check

Valid **government-issued photo identification** is required. The name on your booking must match it **exactly, character for character**. Your face is captured and compared against the identification document.

One property of that comparison deserves stating, because it is unusual: **the identity check never fabricates a match**. Where the comparison cannot be made with confidence, the result is recorded as inconclusive rather than resolved in either direction, and a human decides what happens next. An inconclusive check is not an accusation and does not, by itself, stop you sitting.

3.3 The room scan

A **room scan** is required. You will be asked to show your working area. Clear it first: notes, reference material, personal devices and second screens away, not merely out of shot. The scan exists to establish the state of the room at the start, which protects you as much as it protects the examination.

— 4. During the sitting

4.1 The environment

The examination runs full screen in a secured environment. Copy, cut and paste are disabled. Leaving the examination window or losing focus is **recorded as an integrity event** on your attempt. A **second monitor** connected during the session is detected and blocked. Prohibited applications — browsers, chat, screen-sharing, recording and virtual-machine tools — are detected before launch and while you sit.

You **cannot quit** the examination. You submit when you are ready, or it submits automatically when time expires.

4.2 The clock belongs to the server

Your remaining time is issued by the server, not counted by your machine, and it is confirmed on a regular heartbeat while you sit. Answers are saved continuously against that same heartbeat.

The practical consequence is the one candidates most need to hear: **a disconnection, a crash or a restart does not lose your work and does not reset your clock**. You resume where you left off, with your answers painted back and the correct remaining time. Nor can a slow or manipulated client buy extra minutes — the time is the server's to give.

4.3 Talking to a proctor

A proctor supervises the session and can message you during it; you can reply. Messages travel on the same heartbeat as everything else, so the channel works without a separate connection. If anything is disrupted, **tell the proctor immediately**, follow their instructions, and report what

happened to PCI as soon as the session ends, while the detail is fresh and while the session record can be matched to your account.

— 5. Two ways to sit, one set of rules

The examination is delivered **online with remote proctoring** — in the browser, or through the downloadable **PCI Secure Exam** desktop client — or **at a test centre**. The content, the rules, the timing and the scoring are identical on every route. Choosing the desktop client does not change what is asked of you or how it is marked.

— 6. The secure exam client, described honestly

6.1 What it does

The desktop client is a kiosk application for Windows. It:

- runs a borderless, always-on-top window covering the whole virtual screen, with the system menu and the minimise and maximise controls removed;
- intercepts keystrokes at a low level and swallows the usual escapes — Alt+Tab, Alt+F4, Ctrl+Esc, the Windows key, PrintScreen and their relatives;
- checks running processes against a denylist of browsers, chat, screen-sharing, recording and virtual-machine tools, both before launch and repeatedly while you sit;
- detects a **second monitor connected mid-examination**;
- flags remote-desktop sessions and virtual-machine indicators;
- asks the operating system to **exclude the examination window from screen capture and broadcast**;
- captures webcam evidence at a regular interval and runs face detection continuously;
- monitors microphone level and voice likelihood;
- keeps a locally encrypted cache of your answers and any recorded violations, so a crash loses nothing;
- registers itself for the `pciexam://` link the portal uses to launch it, without needing an administrator or an installer.

6.2 What it cannot do, stated plainly

The client cannot block Ctrl+Alt+Del. The secure attention sequence is reserved by the operating system, and intercepting it would require a signed kernel driver and operating-system notarisation. The client does everything possible in user space and **degrades honestly**: where it cannot enforce something, it logs and warns rather than pretending it has.

Three further limits, in the same spirit:

1. **Capture exclusion is best-effort.** The client asks Windows to exclude its window from capture. It cannot guarantee that a camera pointed at the screen, or hardware outside the operating system, sees nothing.

2. **Virtual-machine and remote-session detection is a hint, not proof.** It raises a flag for a human to consider. It does not decide anything on its own.
3. **The automated proctoring analysis is a baseline.** The default analyser is rule-based — no face, multiple faces, prolonged absence, loud audio, speech — and its findings are events for review, not verdicts. The Institute's governing principle applies to its own tooling: **AI proposes; the professional disposes.** No automated component fabricates a high-confidence identity match, and **no scoring ever happens on your machine.**

6.3 Why the client is pinned to PCI, and what that protects

The client will only talk to an approved PCI host. A launch link that names some other server is **ignored**, and the client refuses to start against an untrusted host. The portal hands the client a **short-lived, single-use launch code** rather than a session token, and that code is redeemed against the pinned host.

That design is doing something for you, not only for the Institute: a link that arrives by email claiming to start your examination cannot point the client at somebody else's server, and a launch code captured in transit is worth nothing once it has been redeemed.

6.4 What IT departments usually ask

The client is a per-user application that registers a link handler for the current user; it needs a camera, a microphone and outbound HTTPS to the pinned PCI host. It runs a machine-readiness self-test that exits cleanly with a pass or fail, which is usually the fastest way to settle an approval conversation. Run that self-test on the managed build before exam day, not on the morning.

— 7. Evidence: what is captured, and what happens to it

7.1 What is captured

- **Image evidence** — webcam snapshots at a regular interval, currently configured at 15 seconds, and the frames from your room scan. Both intervals and thresholds are administrator-configurable and may change; the principle does not.
- **Integrity events** — a timestamped timeline: no face detected, more than one face, an absence beyond a configured threshold (currently 8 seconds), loud audio, detected speech, focus loss, a prohibited process, a second display, a remote-session indicator.
- **The identity check result** — verified, inconclusive or failed, with its supporting images.
- **Session telemetry** — connection health, client type, answers and remaining time on each heartbeat.

The microphone is monitored to raise events about sound level and voice likelihood; the evidence stored is image evidence.

7.2 How long it is kept

Proctoring evidence is retained for audit for a defined period and then purged automatically. **[CONFIRM: the published proctoring-evidence retention period — the platform currently seeds 365 days].**

Personal data, identity documents and proctoring evidence are handled under the Institute's privacy notice — the fourth of the seven consents — and retained only as long as needed for certification and audit.

7.3 Who sees it

Staff with the relevant permission, for the purpose of running and auditing examinations: a live proctoring console during the sitting, and a session record afterwards showing the identity result, the event timeline, the evidence gallery and the server-calculated score. Access is permissioned by role, and privileged actions on a session are written to an audit log.

— 8. Evidence is audit-only by default

This is the point where PCI's configuration differs from what candidates expect, and it is in the candidate's favour.

Proctoring and identity evidence does not, by itself, delay or block your result. The automatic rules that could hard-block a result on a tampered attempt, a critical violation or a failed identity check are **switched off by default**, deliberately, so that evidence is collected for audit and reviewed by people rather than acted on automatically by a threshold. Immediate publication is the default ([CER-07 §2](#)).

An event on your timeline is therefore not a penalty. It is a record that a human may look at.

— 9. When a result is held

Where there is a genuine question about the validity of an attempt, the result is **held** pending review. While it is held:

- **you see no score;**
- **you see no pass or fail;**
- **you see no domain breakdown.**

You are told plainly that the result is pending and why. This is deliberate. Showing a provisional number that may later be withdrawn is worse for the candidate than showing none: it invites a decision — telling an employer, accepting a role, ordering business cards — that the review may reverse. A held result is resolved by people, with a right of appeal against the outcome. [CER-07 §§4 and 6](#).

— 10. What is expected of you

- Work **alone**, in a quiet room you can close, on a **single screen**.
 - Notes, reference material and personal devices **away**, not merely closed.
 - A **second monitor physically disconnected**, not switched off.
-

- Government-issued photo identification **physically present**.
 - The proctor's instructions followed throughout.
 - **No AI tool, assistant or service of any kind**, on any device, for any purpose. In preparation AI is welcome; in the examination it is prohibited, and its use is misconduct.
 - **No disclosure of examination content**, during or after the sitting.
-

— 11. How this goes wrong

- **Testing on the wrong machine.** The single most common cause of an exam-day failure, and entirely preventable. §3.1.
 - **A second screen switched off but still connected.** Detection is of the connection, not the power state. §10.
 - **A room "tidied" out of shot.** The scan establishes the state of the room; material pushed just outside the frame is exactly what a reviewer will ask about.
 - **Panicking at a disconnection.** The clock belongs to the server and your answers are saved. Reconnect, resume, and report it afterwards. §4.2.
 - **Treating an inconclusive identity check as a rejection.** It means the comparison was not confident enough to assert anything. A human decides. §3.2.
 - **Assuming an integrity event has failed you.** Evidence is audit-only by default. §8.
 - **Expecting a provisional score while a result is held.** There is none, on purpose. §9.
 - **Installing the client for the first time on exam day.** Install and self-test in the week before, on the machine you will use, especially on a managed corporate build. §6.4.
-

— 12. The room checklist

Run this the evening before, in the room you will sit in.

- [] Readiness check completed **on this machine, this network, this room**
 - [] Secure client installed and self-test passed, if you are using it
 - [] Second monitor physically disconnected
 - [] Desk clear: no notes, no reference material, no phone, no smartwatch
 - [] Door closed, household informed of the time and the duration
 - [] Government-issued photo identification on the desk, name matched to the booking
 - [] Browsers, chat, screen-sharing and recording applications closed
 - [] Power connected; laptop not relying on battery for 90 minutes
 - [] Backup network known — a phone hotspot you have actually tested
 - [] Booking time confirmed in the booking's recorded timezone
 - [] Launch planned for the 15-minute early window, not the grace period
-

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — where the sitting fits in the whole journey
- [CER-05 – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation](#) — the launch window and grace period referred to throughout
- [CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints](#) — what happens to the result, held or otherwise
- [EXB-07 – Examination security and integrity](#) — the item-bank and scheme-level security this sits inside

— Sources and standards

- PCI Secure Exam client documentation ([secureexam/README-SECUREEXAM.md](#)), 2026 — including its published capability statement on user-space lockdown and the secure attention sequence.
- PCI platform proctoring, evidence and result-publication settings, verified August 2026 — identity check, room scan, second-monitor block, evidence interval, absence threshold, and the default-off automatic result-blocking rules described in §8.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §4.1, August 2026.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

Results, scoring, appeals and complaints

How the outcome is decided, what the domain breakdown will and will not tell you, and how to challenge a decision

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A PCI result is issued immediately on submission with a domain-by-domain breakdown, and is criterion-referenced: everyone who demonstrates the standard passes, regardless of how many others do. This document explains how the score is produced, why the configured 65 % pass mark and the standard-setting study still to come are both true statements, what happens when a result is held or invalidated, how the credential is issued and verified, and how to appeal a decision or raise a complaint through the two separate routes that exist for them.

— About this document

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Results, scoring, appeals and complaints

In one paragraph. A PCI result is issued immediately on submission with a domain-by-domain breakdown, and is criterion-referenced: everyone who demonstrates the standard passes, regardless of how many others do. This document explains how the score is produced, why the configured 65 % pass mark and the standard-setting study still to come are both true statements, what happens when a result is held or invalidated, how the credential is issued and verified, and how to appeal a decision or raise a complaint through the two separate routes that exist for them.

Who this is for. Candidates about to sit or just finished; unsuccessful candidates planning a resit; credential holders whose status is under review; and employers verifying a credential they are relying on.

— 1. How the result is produced

1.1 Scored by the server, always

Scoring happens on PCI's servers. It never happens on your machine, in the browser or in the desktop client, whichever route you sit by. The answer key is versioned, the item bank version is recorded against your attempt, and a re-scoring can therefore be reproduced exactly.

1.2 Immediate, with a breakdown

On submission you receive your score, a pass or fail outcome, and a **domain-by-domain breakdown** showing where you performed above, at or below target. For a successful candidate the breakdown is a professional development map. For an unsuccessful one it is the map for a targeted resit.

1.3 Criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve

Everyone who demonstrates the required standard passes, regardless of how many others do. There is no quota and no fixed proportion who succeed or fail. Your result is not affected by the cohort you happen to sit alongside, by the day you sit, or by how the last hundred candidates performed.

The corollary is the part candidates like less: a near-miss is not rounded up because the paper was hard. A criterion-referenced examination cannot make that concession without abandoning the thing that makes it worth passing.

1.4 The pass mark: two true statements

65 % is the pass mark configured in the platform today. And **the definitive standard will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study**, in which qualified subject-matter experts judge, item by item, what a just-competent candidate would be expected to achieve.

Both statements are true simultaneously, and the Institute publishes both. A body that had already run the study would say so; a body that had not, and quoted a single number without qualification, would be implying work it has not done. [EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark](#) explains the method and what will change when the study reports.

1.5 What is not stated, and will not be invented

No item count exists. The number of items on the examination **will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis** — the study that establishes what the job actually requires and therefore what the examination must sample. Until it reports, no count is published, and any figure quoted elsewhere did not come from PCI. [EXB-06 – Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority](#) covers why the count follows the analysis rather than preceding it.

— 2. Publication is immediate by default

Immediate publication is the default. Proctoring and identity evidence is collected for audit and does **not** by itself delay a valid result: the automatic rules that could hard-block a result are switched off by default and reviewed by people instead ([CER-06 §8](#)).

So the normal case is the simple one. You submit; you see your result; the credential issues on a pass.

— 3. Reading the domain breakdown honestly

The breakdown tells you where your performance sat relative to target in each domain. It is the most useful diagnostic you will get, and it repays being read carefully rather than emotionally.

Three cautions, offered as **professional judgement** rather than as rules:

1. **A domain band is not a precise measurement.** Each domain is sampled by a subset of the examination, and a subset carries more measurement noise than the whole. Treat a single weak domain as a signal worth investigating, not as a calibrated score.
2. **Weakness clusters.** A candidate weak in Domain 6 (earned value and forecasting) is frequently weak in Domain 3 (budgeting and forecasting) for the same underlying reason. Fix the reason, not the band.
3. **The comfortable domains are where preparation is usually wasted.** Practitioners are strong in two or three domains and thinner elsewhere; planners often under-prepare finance and accounting, cost engineers often under-prepare schedule logic. Spend your time in proportion to the published weighting and your weaknesses, not your confidence.

— 4. The result lifecycle

A result moves through recorded states, and it is worth knowing which one you are in.

State	What it means for you
Released	Scored and published. On a pass, the credential issues.
Held	Under review for a genuine question about the validity of the attempt. No score, no pass or fail and no domain breakdown are shown until it resolves.
Credential issued	A pass has been converted into an issued credential with its own identifier.
Invalidated	The attempt has been set aside following a decision. Any credential issued from it is revoked.
Reinstated	An earlier invalidation has been reversed and the position restored.

Two points follow. A held result is deliberately blank rather than provisional — showing a number that might be withdrawn invites decisions the review may reverse (CER-06 §9). And invalidation and reinstatement are **decisions**, made by people, recorded with a reason, and appealable.

— 5. The credential

5.1 The certification decision

Passing the examination is the central requirement, not the whole of it. Certification is awarded after eligibility, assessment, verification and PCI policy requirements are all met. The decision is independent of any training you did or did not take.

5.2 What you receive

A **verifiable digital credential** with a **unique credential identifier**, a **downloadable certificate**, and a downloadable score report. The credential carries an issue date and an expiry date three years later.

5.3 Verification

Anyone holding the credential identifier can check its status through PCI's public verification. Verification is **expiry-aware and status-aware**: it reflects an active credential, an expired one and a revoked one differently. That is the point of it. A verification service that only ever says "yes" is a brochure.

5.4 Using it accurately

The credential belongs to the named individual. It describes competence **at the point of assessment, and thereafter under maintenance**. It may not be transferred, altered or used in a misleading way, and it does not imply accreditation, endorsement, or any employment or salary outcome. Holders are bound by the Code of Ethics and the professional conduct policy, including full accountability for AI-assisted work.

— 6. Appeals

6.1 What may be appealed

Any decision that affects you: an eligibility decision, an examination or result decision, an invalidation, an accommodation decision, or a certification decision.

The platform recognises four case types, and choosing the right one gets your case to the right people first time:

Type	Use it for
Result appeal	A decision about the outcome of an attempt
Invalidation appeal	A decision to set aside an attempt or revoke a credential
Complaint	PCI's conduct, service or process (§7)
Ethics	A concern about professional conduct — yours, another holder's, or the Institute's

6.2 Who decides

An appeal is reviewed **independently of the people who made the original decision**, and is considered by the **Appeals Panel**, a standing governance body distinct from those that make certification decisions. **Raising an appeal never prejudices your standing** — not with the panel, not with the Institute, and not in any future application.

6.3 How to raise one

Submit the appeal from your account, stating the decision you are appealing and your grounds, and attach supporting evidence where you have it. A case is recorded as submitted, moves to under review, and closes as **upheld**, **dismissed** or **withdrawn**, with the decision and its date recorded against it.

6.4 Timescales

[\[CONFIRM: the deadline for submitting an appeal after the decision being appealed\]](#) and [\[CONFIRM: the published acknowledgement and decision timescales for appeals and complaints\]](#).

Until those are published, submit promptly and keep your own record of when you did. This handbook will not invent a number that a candidate might rely on and then be held to.

6.5 What an appeal is and is not

An appeal asks whether the decision was correctly made under the published rules. It is **not** a request for a second opinion on the same evidence, **not** a route to have the standard adjusted for one candidate, and **not** a substitute for a resit. State grounds, not disappointment: what rule you say was misapplied, and what evidence supports that.

6.6 Misconduct outcomes

Where an appeal concerns alleged misconduct, the investigation process and the range of outcomes are governed by the published misconduct procedure and are owned by [ETH-06 – Raising](#)

concerns: [complaints](#), [investigations](#), [sanctions](#). What this handbook commits to is the process: you are told what is alleged, you are given a genuine opportunity to respond, the people deciding have no conflict of interest, and an adverse decision carries a right of appeal.

— 7. Complaints

A **complaint** is about PCI's conduct, service or processes rather than about a decision that changed your status. It is a **separate route with separate people**, deliberately, so that neither kind of concern is decided by those it is about.

Use a complaint where a process failed you — an unanswered request, a session run badly, information that turned out to be wrong. Use an appeal where a decision went against you. If you are unsure, say so in the submission; getting the route wrong delays a case but does not forfeit it.

— 8. Support cases are not appeals

Routine problems — a booking that will not open, a failed upload, a payment that did not register — go through support, which is faster and better suited to them. Raising a support case does not preserve an appeal deadline, and raising an appeal is not the way to get a password reset. Use [CER-03 §5.1](#) to self-diagnose first: most "urgent" cases before a sitting are an outstanding consent or an identity document.

— 9. How this goes wrong

- **Reading a held result as a fail.** It is neither a pass nor a fail. There is no number yet. §4.
 - **Expecting a curve.** Criterion-referenced means the standard does not move for the cohort or for a hard paper. §1.3.
 - **Quoting 65 % as the final standard, or the standard-setting study as evidence that 65 % is wrong.** Both statements are true. §1.4.
 - **Repeating an item count from somewhere else.** None exists. §1.5.
 - **Appealing a result because it was disappointing.** State grounds under the published rules. §6.5.
 - **Missing a deadline while waiting for a support ticket.** §8.
 - **Announcing a pass before the credential issues.** The certification decision follows the result. §5.1.
 - **Assuming an expired credential still verifies as active.** Verification is expiry-aware, and employers use it. §5.3.
-

— 10. Writing an appeal that can be decided

An appeal that a panel can act on contains, in this order:

- [] The decision you are appealing, identified precisely — the attempt, the booking or the case reference, and its date
- [] The date you received the decision
- [] Your grounds, stated as **which rule or process you say was misapplied**
- [] What actually happened, in sequence, with times
- [] Evidence, attached: screenshots with visible timestamps, the support case reference, correspondence
- [] Anything you reported at the time, and when you reported it
- [] What outcome you are asking for
- [] Your contact details and credential or candidate identifier

Two things to do before you submit: check that the outcome you are asking for is one the panel can actually give, and check that everything you assert is something you could evidence if asked.

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the journey this outcome concludes
- [CER-06 – Online proctoring and the secure exam client](#) — what triggers a hold, and what evidence exists
- [CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement](#) — what happens after the credential issues
- [ETH-06 – Raising concerns: complaints, investigations, sanctions](#) — the investigation process and the range of outcomes
- [EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark](#) — how the definitive standard will be set

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform result-lifecycle, credential and appeals records, verified August 2026 — the result states in §4, the four appeal case types in §6.1 and the case statuses in §6.3.
- PCI Candidate Handbook ([docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md](#)), 2026.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §§4.1, 4.2 and 8, August 2026 — including the governance bodies named in §6.2.

— Status and version

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CER-08 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement

The three-year cycle, what counts towards it, and the component you cannot substitute your way out of

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A PCI credential is valid for three years and is maintained by continuing professional development recorded in your PCI account, in four categories, with a mandatory AI-currency component that no other activity can substitute for. Only approved entries dated inside the current cycle count. This document explains how the cycle window is calculated, what evidence a CPD entry needs, why the widely quoted 30-hour figure is a portal target rather than a published requirement, and what recertification and lapse mean for a credential's verified status.

— About this document

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Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement

In one paragraph. A PCI credential is valid for three years and is maintained by continuing professional development recorded in your PCI account, in four categories, with a mandatory AI-currency component that no other activity can substitute for. Only approved entries dated inside the current cycle count. This document explains how the cycle window is calculated, what evidence a CPD entry needs, why the widely quoted 30-hour figure is a portal target rather than a published requirement, and what recertification and lapse mean for a credential's verified status.

Who this is for. Credential holders planning a cycle; managers who need to know what maintaining a certified team actually costs in time; and employers verifying that a credential they rely on is still active.

— 1. Why the credential expires at all

A credential that never expires certifies what someone knew once. That is a defensible claim about the past and a misleading one about the present, and the gap between them widens fastest in exactly the areas this credential covers.

The Institute's position is specific rather than general. Project controls practice moves at the ordinary pace of a professional discipline; **the AI component of it does not**. A holder certified three years ago was assessed against tools, failure modes and governance expectations that have since changed materially. Recertification exists to close that gap, and the AI-currency component exists because closing it is the part a busy professional is most likely to defer.

— 2. The cycle

2.1 Three years, ending at expiry

A credential is valid for **three years**. The **current cycle** is the three-year period ending on the credential's expiry date. Everything you record for recertification must be dated inside that window.

The window is calculated backwards from expiry, not forwards from issue. In the ordinary case the two are the same thing; after a reinstatement or an adjusted expiry date they are not, and the platform's calculation — expiry minus the certification's cycle length — governs.

2.2 Only approved entries count

A CPD entry you create is **recorded**, which means submitted and awaiting review. It counts towards recertification only once it is **approved**. Entries that are recorded but not yet reviewed, and entries that have been rejected, contribute nothing.

This is the single most common surprise at the end of a cycle. A holder with a full log and an empty approved total is not compliant, and the fix — evidence, review, approval — takes longer in month thirty-five than in month two.

2.3 Where it is recorded

CPD is recorded in your PCI account, with a running total shown against the current cycle. Each entry carries an activity date, a category, hours, a description and, where relevant, an evidence file. Credit earned automatically from an attended PCI event is granted **once** per attendee: a retry, a crash or a duplicate scan cannot produce a second credit for the same event.

— 3. The four categories

CPD is organised into four categories of activity:

Category	What it covers
Structured learning	Taught or curriculum-based activity: courses, programmes, workshops, structured webinars
Learning through work	Capability genuinely developed in practice — a first quantitative schedule risk analysis, a first claim narrative, a system implementation
Contribution to the profession	Giving back: mentoring, examining, writing, standards and committee work, speaking
Formal study	Academic or formal qualification study undertaken during the cycle

Two notes on how to use them. **Categorise by what you did, not by what it was called** — a conference is structured learning if you attended sessions and contribution to the profession if you presented, and recording it as both is double counting. And **a category is not a quota**: nothing requires an even spread across four categories, and a cycle weighted towards learning through work is a legitimate cycle for a practitioner in a demanding role.

— 4. The AI-currency requirement

4.1 What it is

The three-year cycle carries a **mandatory AI-currency component**. In your account it appears as a CPD category named exactly that — **AI currency** — and hours recorded under it are counted separately from your total, because the requirement is a floor in its own right and not a share of something else.

4.2 What it is not

It is not a general technology requirement, and it is not satisfied by using AI tools. Using a tool is not currency in it. The component asks for evidence that you have **kept up with what AI can and cannot safely do in your discipline**, which is a different activity from adopting it.

4.3 What genuinely satisfies it

Recommended practice, not an approved list. Activity that would satisfy a reviewer typically shows one of three things:

1. **Capability boundaries** — structured learning about where a class of model fails, how its outputs degrade with poor data, and what it cannot be relied upon to do in cost, schedule, risk or finance work.
2. **Validation practice** — work in which you took an AI-assisted output and established, with a method you could describe to an auditor, whether it could be relied upon. Challenging an AI-generated forecast and documenting what you validated is stronger evidence than completing a course about forecasting.
3. **Governance contribution** — building, reviewing or applying controls over AI use in a project or an organisation: model registers, human-review gates, disclosure requirements, data-handling rules.

The governing principle is the same one the credential was awarded against: **AI proposes; the professional disposes**. The AI-currency component asks you to demonstrate that you are still competent to be the one who disposes.

4.4 It cannot be substituted

Excess hours in another category do not satisfy the AI-currency component. A cycle that is otherwise complete but empty in this category is an incomplete cycle. The Institute treats this as the load-bearing part of maintenance, because it is the part that makes the credential mean something current rather than something dated.

— 5. How many hours

No binding hours requirement is published today, and this document will not invent one.

Three statements, all true and often conflated:

1. The student portal displays a **target of 30 hours per three-year cycle**. It is a target the portal shows. **It is not a published requirement and no holder can be held to it.**
2. The platform's required-hours setting for the certification currently **defaults to zero**, which is the honest configuration for a requirement that has not yet been published.
3. The binding requirement **will be published with the recertification rules**.

[CONFIRM: the binding CPD hours requirement per three-year cycle — 30 hours is a student-portal target, not a published requirement]

[CONFIRM: the mandatory AI-currency hours required within a cycle, as a subset of the total]

What to do in the meantime. Record everything, dated and evidenced, from the first month of your cycle. A holder with a complete, evidenced, approved log is compliant with any requirement that is subsequently published at or below their total. A holder who waited for the number is not, and cannot retrospectively acquire hours they did not do.

— 6. Worked example — which activities fall inside the cycle

Illustrative figures. The dates and activities are invented to show how the cycle window and the approval rule interact.

The facts. A credential expires on **12 June 2028**. The cycle length is three years, so the current cycle runs from **12 June 2025** to **12 June 2028**. The holder's log contains:

Activity	Date	Category	Hours	Status	Counts?
Cost engineering short course	3 May 2025	Structured learning	12.0	Approved	No — dated before the cycle start
First quantitative schedule risk analysis	14 Nov 2025	Learning through work	8.0	Approved	Yes
Model-limitations workshop	22 Feb 2026	AI currency	6.0	Approved	Yes
Conference attendance	9 Sep 2026	Structured learning	7.0	Recorded	No — not yet approved
Mentoring two junior planners	2027, ongoing	Contribution	10.0	Approved	Yes
Validating an AI-assisted cost forecast	18 Jan 2028	AI currency	4.0	Approved	Yes

The arithmetic.

Approved hours inside the cycle = $8.0 + 6.0 + 10.0 + 4.0 = \mathbf{28.0 \text{ hours}}$. Of which AI currency = $6.0 + 4.0 = \mathbf{10.0 \text{ hours}}$.

Excluded: 12.0 hours dated before the cycle start, and 7.0 hours recorded but not approved — **19.0 hours of genuine activity that contributes nothing**, purely on dates and status.

The assumptions the answer depends on. That the cycle start is expiry minus three years; that every "approved" entry above has in fact been approved rather than merely submitted; and that no entry is double-counted across categories. Whether 28.0 hours is sufficient cannot be stated here, because the binding requirement is not yet published (§5) — which is exactly why the conference entry sitting unapproved for eighteen months is a risk rather than a rounding detail.

— 7. Evidence and audit

A CPD entry stands on four things: **a date, a category, hours you could defend, and a description specific enough that a reviewer can tell what you actually did**. Attach evidence where you have it — a certificate, an agenda, a deliverable, a confirmation.

CPD is subject to review, and evidence may be requested. Write each entry as though it will be the one that is audited: "AI workshop, 6 hours" is a claim; "Six-hour workshop on failure modes of time-series forecasting models in cost applications, certificate attached, applied to the Q3 forecast review" is a record.

— 8. Recertifying, and what happens if you lapse

8.1 Recertifying

Recertification is completed within the cycle, on the basis of approved CPD in that cycle. It is a maintenance decision, not a fresh assessment: it does not require you to re-sit the examination. A renewal fee applies — seeded in the platform at **USD 99**, and confirmed at checkout, which is the amount that binds you.

8.2 Lapse

Letting a cycle end without recertifying **suspends the credential's active status** until the recertification requirements are met. This is not cosmetic: public verification is expiry-aware, so an employer or client checking your credential identifier sees the change ([CER-07](#) §5.3).

[CONFIRM: the grace period after expiry, if any, and the published requirements for reinstating a lapsed credential]

8.3 What a lapse does not do

It does not erase the fact that you passed the examination, and it does not restart your eligibility. Recertification is about currency, not about re-earning entry.

— 9. How this goes wrong

- **Logging activity but never getting it approved.** Recorded is not approved, and only approved counts. §2.2.
 - **Recording activity from the wrong side of the cycle boundary.** Good work, dated three weeks early, counts for nothing. §6.
 - **Treating 30 hours as the rule.** It is a portal target. Record what you actually do and evidence it. §5.
 - **Trying to substitute for AI currency.** Nothing else satisfies it. §4.4.
 - **Recording tool use as AI currency.** Using a tool is not currency in it. §4.2.
 - **Double counting one activity across two categories.** §3.
 - **Discovering the requirement in month thirty-four.** The failure mode this whole document exists to prevent: a compliant cycle is built from month one, in twenty-minute entries, not assembled in a fortnight from memory.
 - **Assuming a lapsed credential still verifies as active.** It does not, and the people who check are the ones whose opinion matters. §8.2.
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— 10. The cycle checklist

Set this up in the week you are certified, not in the year you expire.

- [] Expiry date recorded in your own calendar, with a reminder at 24 months and at 30 months
 - [] Cycle start calculated (expiry minus three years) and written down
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- [] A single place to keep evidence as it arrives, not reconstructed later
- [] CPD entered within a month of each activity, with date, category, hours, specific description and evidence attached
- [] Approval status checked quarterly — anything still "recorded" chased
- [] At least one **AI-currency** activity planned in each year of the cycle, not saved for the last
- [] A note of which activities were AI currency, kept separately from the total
- [] Recertification started well before expiry, not in the final month

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the whole journey, of which this is the standing obligation
- [CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints](#) — how credential status and verification work
- [AIG-12 – The AI-literate controls professional](#) — what "keeping current" actually consists of
- [ETH-01 – The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct](#) — the accountability that maintenance supports
- [CMP-08 – Data, digital and AI competencies in depth](#) — the competencies the AI-currency component keeps alive

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform CPD and recertification logic, verified August 2026 — the cycle-window calculation, the approved-entries-only rule, the separately counted AI-currency category, the exactly-once event credit, and the required-hours setting that currently defaults to zero.
- PCI Candidate Handbook ([docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md](#)), 2026.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §§4.2 and 4.5, August 2026.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.